

LEFT WITHOUT POWER

Now that their 15 minutes of fame are over on TV talk shows, the limelight-loving Left leaders are adjusting to life offscreen

■ By Shafi Rahman

Last week the Left leaders went into a sulk on a draft released by the World Trade Organisation (WTO). Thundered a CPI(M) statement, "The US is exerting pressure upon India to fall in line and facilitate the adoption of an iniquitous agreement. The US President had called up the Indian prime minister in this connection. The UPA Government should not compromise India's stand at the WTO talks in Geneva."

Rousing words. Just a month ago, they would have been replayed on more than a dozen news channels, sending UPA's muddle managers into a twirl. This time the UPA Government didn't bother to clarify its position. "We don't expect to get answers nowadays," sniffed a Left leader. Yes, and neither can they count on airtime.

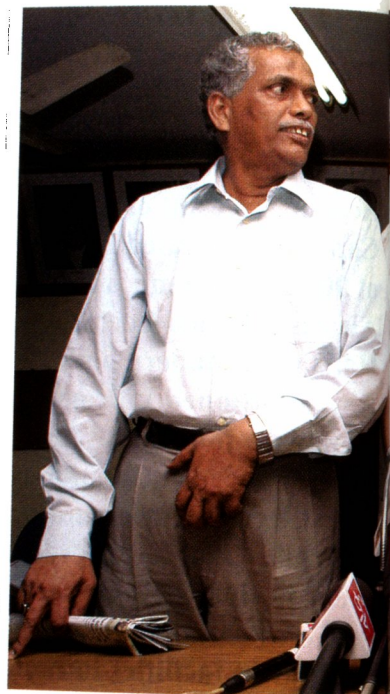
Result? The stars of the Left anti-Government gaggle, who once hung around the Capital waiting to assuage the insatiable appetite of 24x7 television, have now left the air-conditioned comforts of TV studios and the pleasures of pounding Delhi podiums to feel the heat and dust of ground-level campaigning. So while CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat went to West Bengal and Kerala to explain Speaker Somnath Chatterjee's ouster, his wife and Politburo colleague Brinda Karat travelled to Khanamam district in Andhra Pradesh. Her agenda? To oppose the state Government's plan to suspend the National Rural Employment Guarantee Programme during the peak agriculture season, in the process negating her own comrade and

Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan, who advocates a similar suspension of the programme.

Another favoured talking head, Sitaram Yechury, went on a hopping spree to Tiruchirappalli, Bangalore and Mumbai, all within a week. Senior Politburo member M.K. Pandhe, who has been muted by the party after his not-so-pleasing comments on Muslim displeasure over the Indo-US nuclear deal, will travel to Puri in Orissa to attend a CPI(M) function.

It's a story repeated in other Left establishments, once buzzing with hyperactive soundbyte warriors. The Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) office, formerly a haven of insider stories, is deserted and its General Secretary Chandrachoodan is firmly ensconced in the backwaters of his home state, Kerala. All India Forward Block (AIFB) leader G. Devarajan is travelling in Kerala and West Bengal. The CPI's D. Raja—for whom the DMK rolled out the red carpet each time he landed at Chennai in the last four years—was arrested and thrown behind bars for protesting outside the Sri Lankan Deputy High Commission in the city on July 30. Only RSP Secretary Abani Roy is in Delhi and is available for interviews. Sadly, few are willing to bite the bait.

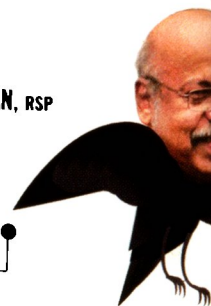
Now that television's Circus Maximus is through, the CPI(M) has decided to take its carnival to the streets. The Left trade unions have called for a nationwide industrial strike on August 20 to register their protest against the "anti-people" economic policies of the Congress-led Govern-



G. DEVARAJAN, AIFB
TONGUE TWISTER
Is deploying his multi-lingual skills to benefit the party cadre



T.J. CHANDRACHOODAN, RSP
SUDDEN STAR
Has vanished into the party fold after his nano-second of fame



PRAKASH KARAT, CPI(M)
CARROT AND STICK
No longer keeps track of newswires and is travelling in Kerala and West Bengal